



The airport's 7,545 ft- (2,300 m-) long runway is relatively short by modern standards, and it stretches close to the airport's boundary with the beach. An Airbus A330, which can carry more than 200 passengers, needs at least 3,280 ft (1,000 m)—preferably more—to come to a halt once it has touched down. As a result, pilots make their approach over

the shimmering waters of the Caribbean as low as they can, in order to get their plane's wheels on the tarmac as quickly as possible. Planes can be just 65 to 100 ft (20 to 30 m) above the ground by the time they fly over the beach. Maho may not be the best beach on the island, but it draws large crowds of plane-spotters, eager to get close to big airliners in flight.